OPS-READY RUNBOOK

Operating the Governed Pipeline

How to start it, what to watch, what to do when something goes wrong, when to stop, and how to roll back.

Vijayalakshmi Ramu | October 2026 | github.com/Viji-qmofi/first-microservices-Viji-R-agentic-harness-cicd

THE NINE STOPS

1. A plan proposes a change visible outside the codebase.
2. Two reviewers contradict each other on the same section.
3. The test step returns `valid: false`.
4. Any MCP call returns `authorization_denied`. Do not retry under another role.
5. `decision-auditor` proposes a correction. It is flagged even though the role may act.
6. The diff does not match the claimed scope.
7. A plan has been revised three times.
8. A required MCP server is unreachable. Start it and restart, or abandon the task.
9. The task exceeds $2.00 or 900 seconds, or a subagent has not returned in 10 minutes.

Every response in this runbook fails toward stopping and asking the human, never toward continuing in a degraded mode. Never bypass a required CI check: read the job's steps, not only its color.

Owner and escalation. There is one operator, who is also the person who approves commits. Anything below that says "stop" means stop and decide yourself; no one else is paged.

01 Start a session

1. Build the image if needed and run the container with the command in the `README.md` Quick Start. Mount `claude-auth` at `/claude-auth`, not `/root/.claude`.
2. Inside the container, start the two HTTP MCP servers and register them (commands in `README.md`). They must be running before `claude` starts, and a server started mid-session is not seen by that session.
3. Run `claude`, check the header names the intended model, and run `/mcp` to confirm `storage`, `retrieval` and `coursetools` are connected.
4. End with `exit`, not Ctrl+C, so the login is saved.

02 What to watch

Each run:

- Cost and time against the budgets: $2.00 and 900 seconds per task (status line and a `date` before and after).
- The saved transcript in `.eval-artifacts/runs/<task>.json` and its `.log`.
- The audit logs in `.memory/storage/`: `storage-audit.log` and `retrieval-audit.log`. Denied calls are recorded there. The Orchestrator can read the storage log with `audit_read`.

Each pull request:

- The four required checks: Policy Test Suite, Governed File Check, Evaluation Harness, Pipeline Integrity Check. Open a job's step list, not only its color, because a conditional gate that is not triggered still shows green with every step skipped.
- The `audit-trail` artifact (`ci-audit-trail-<sha>.json`, kept 90 days), which records what each gate did.
- The `advisory-review` artifact. A green advisory job proves nothing until the review text is read.

03 Incidents: what you see, what to do first

- **An agent says something false, or does more than asked** (playbook 1, 3). Do not accept its summary. Check the raw artifact: the diff, the log, the file. Use the `verify-before-trusting` skill. If it went beyond scope, stop the run.
- **A call is denied with** `authorization_denied` (7). Stop. Do not retry under another role. Read the audit log. Widen a grant only by a pull request with a stated reason (`ADR-007`).
- **A caller claims a role it is not** (8). This is a known limit: roles are self-declared. Treat an unexpected claim as an escalation.
- **The allow-list file is missing** (9). `coursetools` refuses to start. Restore the file from git and restart.
- **An MCP server is down or its tools are missing** (11). Start both servers, restart `claude`, confirm with `/mcp`. Do not continue without them.
- **Agents or skills missing from the session** (12). The `claude-auth` volume is mounted at the wrong path. Mount it at `/claude-auth`.
- **A shell script fails on Windows line endings** (14). Check `.gitattributes` (`eol=lf`) and re-checkout the file.
- **A record is stale and treated as fact** (15). Run `decision-auditor` to check records against git state.
- **A gate is green but did nothing** (18). Read its steps. Check the classifier's path filter in `.github/workflows/ci.yml`.
- **A gate is weakened** (19). Do not merge. Revert the workflow change. On `main`, treat it as a P0.
- **The image will not pull,** `429 Too Many Requests` (21). Re-run the job later. The build already retries and falls back to a mirror. Do not bypass a required check.
- **The model API credit runs out** (22). Add credit in the Anthropic Console, then re-run all jobs. Do not bypass the required check.
- **The advisory review is green but contains an error** (23). Read the artifact. Fix the cause, usually the entry above.

- **A CI job is cancelled at its time limit** (24). Find the step that was running. Re-run once if the cause is a slow registry or runner. If it recurs, raise the ceiling in `ci.yml` with a stated reason. Do not bypass a required check. Note that a cancelled Policy Test Suite also skips Governed File Check, Evaluation Harness and Advisory Code Review.
- **Cost or time runs over, or a subagent does not return** (6). Stop and ask: continue, scope down, or abandon.

04 When to stop and escalate

Stop and involve the human, and do not proceed automatically, when:

- a plan proposes a change visible outside the codebase;
- two reviewers contradict each other on the same section;
- the test step returns `valid: false`;
- any MCP call returns `authorization_denied`;
- `decision-auditor` proposes a correction (it is flagged even though the role may act);
- the diff does not match the claimed scope;
- a plan has been revised three times;
- a required MCP server is unreachable;
- the task exceeds $2.00 or 900 seconds, or a subagent has not returned in 10 minutes.

Details: `module4_doc/escalation-and-rollback-criteria.md` and `CLAUDE.md`.

05 Rollback

`main` requires a pull request, so every rollback is a revert pull request with the required checks.

- **A deterministic conversion regresses.** Revert the single conversion commit: `git revert <sha>`, push on a branch, open the PR.
- `pipeline-integrity` **fails on** `main`**.** P0. Merge nothing else until the failure named in `integrity-report.json` is fixed.
- **A widened grant is later tied to a near-miss.** Revert that allow-list commit. Re-apply only with the evidence standard in `ADR-007`.
- `eval-gate` **fails on** `main`**.** Do not merge more agent-affecting changes until it is diagnosed as a real defect (fix first) or a known unrelated gap (document it and proceed). Never ignore it silently.
- **A memory entry is wrong or obsolete.** Do not delete it. Move it to `.memory/project/archived/` with the reason, and update `MEMORY_INDEX.md`.

06 Reliability and cost controls, and their honest status

- **Job timeouts.** Configured on all seven CI jobs (`timeout-minutes`). Exercised on a throwaway pull request: with the Policy Test Suite limit set to 1 minute, GitHub cancelled the job mid-build (PR #23, run 38971124589). The limits are fixed ceilings, not tuned to measured run times.
- **Build retry and mirror fallback.** Three attempts, then the AWS ECR Public mirror. Exercised on a throwaway PR with a simulated failure (PR #10). A real registry rate limit cannot be triggered on demand.
- **Fail closed.** Exercised by a real incident: the Evaluation Harness stayed red when the API credit ran out (playbook 22).
- **Per-task budget ($2.00, 900 seconds).** The after-the-fact check in the evaluation harness has fired on a real run (HO-06). It also fired in CI on a deliberately lowered ceiling: HO-02's real cost of $0.95 against a $0.50 budget failed the required Evaluation Harness (PR #24, run 38972843072). The live guard in `CLAUDE.md` is defined only.
- **Plan-revision limit (three) and subagent stall (10 minutes).** Defined only.
- **MCP server unreachable.** Exercised: the Orchestrator halted and offered only "start and restart" or "abandon" (playbook 11).

07 After any incident

1. Record it in `module3_doc/calibration-log.md` with evidence: a transcript, an audit-log line, or a commit, not a summary.
2. Add or update the playbook entry with the same fields, and mark it Defined only until the response has actually been used.
3. If a grant changes, follow `ADR-007`: a stated, cited reason tied to the role's job.